CFP Workshops
Facilitator/Presenter Notes

G'day!

Thank you for your interest in running a CFP Workshop.

The goal of this workshop is to:

- Encourage people from all walks of life to consider speaking at a conference
- Support first time presenters submit talk ideas to PyCon AU
- Break down barriers and imposter syndrome that prevents people from proposing talk ideas to conference

By making this workshop freely available and delivering it through local communities, we also aim to build a pipeline of presenters for local user groups; strengthening local communities around Australia.

Please feel free to run this workshop verbatim, or modify it to your local language, community or technology. Resources for this workshop are licensed under the Attribution-NonCommercial-ShareAlike 4.0 International Creative Commons license, so please publish your modifications.

We welcome your questions and notes. To promote a workshop running before 29 March 2026, please email **program@pycon.org.au**. We can tentatively support with light catering and stickers too.

Kind Regards,
Jack Skinner
PyCon AU 2026 Conference Director

CFP Workshop - Recommended resources

The workshop is intended to run in approximately a 1 hour session. It can be shortened slightly, and a longer session would allow for more hands-on writing time. We recommend you do a dry-run privately to gauge presentation timing.

To run this workshop effectively, we recommend you arrange:

- A co-facilitator. This person sets the music going, runs the microphone around and can be an overall backup to your facilitation.
- A venue where attendees can sit with laptops or pen and paper. Theatre style seating works less well than tables + chairs.
- A presentation screen - while it's a hands-on workshop, the session is led via slides and presentation.
- A microphone so attendees can hear you clearly. 2x microphones can help by allowing your co-facilitator to run a microphone around the room for share back sections.

Most attendees complete the workshop on their laptop or phone. The “notes” app works perfectly well. You might wish to supply some pen + paper for attendees that do not come prepared.

Whilst not required, we found the 5-10 minute working blocks strangely awkward when in a silent room. Setup some background music (gentle, low volume) to fill the room.

Snacks! In the evening, pizza works well. During the day, a small sugar hit can help creativity.

Lastly, stickers! Typically speaking we give out the “PyCon AU 2026” sticker to anyone who shows up, and reserve the “curlyboi” sticker for people who submit to Pretalx by the end of the workshop.

CFP Workshop - Presenters notes

Slide 1:

- Keep this slide for welcome & housekeeping.
- Make sure to remind attendees you have a code of conduct in place.
- If you are recording your workshop, be explicit whether or not the 'share back' sections will be recorded. By default, we did not record any attendee/participant contributions.

Slide 2: About PyCon AU

- Outline:
    - Workshops on Wednesday
    - Talks (incl. specialist tracks & main conference) Thursday, Friday, Saturday
    - Hands-on coding during the "sprints" happens on Sunday.
- Emphasise that we welcome all talks that are relevant to people who use Python. Talks do not have to have python code on slides, or have python as the main topic of the talk.
- We welcome everyone who might use Python, or who might use Python in the future.

Slide 3:

- Commonly referred to as "CFP", it's an open call for anyone and everyone to submit an idea to present.
- The main conference is for broad general interest topics, relevant to most attendees
- The specialist tracks are typically one day focused mini-conferences, dedicated to a particular industry or niche.
- In 2026 there are 6 specialist tracks. All talks submitted to a track are also considered for the main conference.

Slide 4:

- Emphasise that everyone attending the workshop should be able to submit a draft talk to the CFP before they leave the workshop.

Slide 5: Icebreaker #1

- Encourage participation. Ask the audience to pick their favourite talk idea.

Slide 6: Icebreaker #2

- Encourage participation. Ask the audience for a different talk idea than what's on screen.

Slide 7: Icebreaker #1

- Encourage participation. Can anyone think of how the title format might apply to a talk idea they already have?

Slide 8: Brainstorming

- (Typically, you can just read the bullet points on the slide)
- Highlight that PyCon AU is a practitioner conference. We value hands-on stories and 'lessons learned'. Personal stories are extremely valid and valuable.
- We welcome everyone, from early in career to seasoned industry veterans. We do a lot to support first time speakers if selected.
- Give it 1-2 minutes, but read the room on when to continue. Nudge people to have between 1 - 4 ideas written down.

Slide 9: Starting your proposal

- Prompt everyone to pick one idea from their brainstorming. We'll write a summary about that idea, then turn it into a talk abstract.
- (Typically, you can just read the bullet points on the slide)
- Read out the example on the slide, slowly and clearly. You can mention that Hailey was a high school student when they submitted their talk proposal.
- It's normal to write your summary first, and then turn to your talk title. Titles can be difficult to write, and they can change throughout the creative drafting process.
- Start a timer - but read the room on when to continue. Aim for 5+ minutes.

Slide 10: Improve the idea

- (Typically, you can just read the bullet points on the slide)
- Read Hailey's example further.
- This time is set aside to refine and improve on the summary you've started writing in the previous step. Focusing on clarity and audience. Emphasis on using words or language relevant to a specific audience, industry or niche.

Slide 11: Time to share

- Read the room and choose between 'share with someone next to you' or 'share with the group'.
- Try to respond with a positive "yes and" here. There are (usually) no bad ideas!

Slide 12: (No title - CFP structure)

- (Typically, you can just read the bullet points on the slide)
- Emphasise that the description and notes are optional, and that notes are not published
- Emphasise that everything in your title, abstract, description and notes should be anonymised. Do not identify who you are by mentioning a specific project, pronouns or your employer/organisation.
- The summary we wrote earlier, typically forms the abstract of the talk. Sometimes you can split it into the abstract + description.

Slide 13: Keep expanding

- For longer sessions, run this to a 10 minute timer.
- For shorter sessions, you can skip this step and set it as 'homework'.
- This is all about writing the (optional) description for the talk.
- Tip: If the talk title or abstract poses a question or thesis, the description should answer the question, or at least indicate how the talk will answer the question.
- Goal: The description should give attendees a clear understanding of what they will learn by attending your talk. It should also give reviewers that you have a plan for your talk (which you can expand upon in the notes to reviewers)

Slide 14: Important Tips

- Highlight that PyCon AU has a blind review process to remove as much bias from talk selection as possible. Anonymous proposals mean everyone gets a fair and equal review.
- Don't pretend to be an expert when you're not. Embrace being a learner. Talks are de-anonymised before final selection.
- PyCon AU is a conference attended by both professionals and hobbyists. We LOVE having fun while we work, and there's a fun and whimsy about the conference culture.
- IMPORTANT: If you don't have a Q&A with a conference organiser or program reviewer, additionally mention the two questions / answers from slide 18.

Slide 15: Here to help

- Ask for feedback in a targeted and specific way. Aim for getting practical feedback, not just 'yeah its good'. For example:
    - "If you had to change one thing in the proposal to improve it, what would you change and why?"
    - "What resonated with you most, and why".
- Financial assistance is prioritised for speakers traveling domestically from Australia or from nearby pacific islands who do not have a proximate Python conference. EVERYONE is eligible to apply.

Slide 16: Reasons talks get declined

- Give reviewers confidence that you can fill approximately 25 minutes + 5 mins questions, on your topic. Too much detail and reviewers will be concerned about depth and detail. Too little detail and reviewers don't know what you're going to talk about.
- We know everyone uses AI to overcome writers block. Our reviewers are our peers across industries. We don't use AI to review talks, and we appreciate humans writing proposals in return.
- Topics must be "relevant to people who use Python". We welcome adjacent talks, but be clear why it's relevant to the audience.
- IMPORTANT: The more, high-quality proposals that get submitted, the more difficult it is to finalise the program. This also guarantees an awesome conference schedule. Sometimes talks get declined simply because they're one of several excellent talks on a topic and we have to draw the line. Rejection doesn't mean your ideas is necessarily bad or unwelcome.

Slide 17: Maggie Fero quote

- (Read the bluesky post quoted)
- Posted mid February 2026 if attendees wish to find the thread
- Maggie expands on the idea: "If I offer someone a pen and they decline, it doesn't mean they hate me. Reframe it as offering the conference a talk they don't need this year."

Slide 18: Q&A
Typically this session is a ‘fireside chat’ with either a conference organiser, or a member of the program review committee. It’s intended to start with two moderator questions (you asking the organiser), followed by open Q&A from participants.

The following questions/answers should be planned with your guest.

Keep an eye on timing. Aim for 5-10 minutes.

Q: What information are you looking for in a talk proposal?
A: Confidence on the depth and timing. Relevance to people who use Python, and of interest to the audience who attends PyCon AU. Diversity of ideas and experiences is important, as well as diversity among speakers.

Q: How do talks get reviewed & selected?
A: We have three stages. Anonymous review where we score between +2 and -2, with comments. This stage helps us avoid unconscious bias. Then we de-anonymise talks, and revisit reviews, assessing the speaker's experience in the domain etc. Finally we have a ‘big meeting’ where we discuss the scores and comments and select the final program. Internally we joke about this being the thunderdome (where the organisers sanity enters and an exciting conference program leaves). IMPORTANT: We don’t blindly select the most popular talks - we assess the overall shape and structure of the program. For example: sometimes a highly scored talk will be declined because it’s one of many highly scored talks on a particular topic - that does not mean it was a bad proposal or the idea is invalid.

Q: Can you submit more than one talk?
A: Yes! We often get multiple submissions from speakers. Typically speaking we ask you to submit no more than 2-3 talks. If you have more ideas than that, focus on improving your proposal for your top 1-3 talk ideas. Quality is better than quantity. As a side note: more proposals means more rejections. While receiving many different proposals does help us form an awesome program, we typically only accept one talk per person.

Slide 19: Homework

- Local communities and meetups don't need full descriptions and notes. Typically a title and a sentence or two summary is enough. Consider sharing your talk idea with a local meetup like <this one!>
- Think about how you're going to transform your abstract and description into a longer talk. Expect acceptances in early May, so 15 weeks between acceptance and speaking.
- A very flexible rule of thumb is a slide a minute. For a 25 minute talk, that means writing a slide every week between now and PyCon AU!

Slide 20: Submit early and often!

- Workshop is complete. You have a title and an abstract to submit to the conference
- (Optional) Set aside 5-10 minutes for attendees to sign up to Pretalx and submit their idea. You can edit a proposals right up to the CFP close - so submit now and edit later.
- "AOE" means anywhere on earth. In Australia, it means we get until later on Monday 30 March 2026... but don't leave it to the last minute!
- It's better to submit a draft idea and have a chance at speaking, than to delay submitting to polish or perfect... and then forget to submit by mistake!

Workshop finished! Congratulations! You just ran a CFP Workshop, nice work!